The Night Archive

FREE FIRST CASE - START HERE

Two separate clues. One answer to find together.

After the last visitor leaves, Nao and Ren prepare tomorrow's "Harbor Memories" exhibition. In this complete free case, help them find the entrance map using their separate records.

English only. Short text puzzles for 1-2 players. Use a table, paper and a pen. No timer, app, cutting or extra equipment is required.

Print single-sided on A4 at actual size. Keep each Player A sheet separate from its Player B sheet. Do not print two pages on the same side.

Before each case

Both players may read the shared information. Give the A sheet to Player A and the B sheet to Player B. Read only your own clue, then discuss it aloud. Keep the answer-and-ending sheet face down until you choose an answer or decide to reveal it.

Each clue sheet has an optional hint at the bottom. Fold that part back or cover it before handing out the sheet. Hints and answers may be used whenever you want.

Solo play: read A and B in turn. No host needs to read the solution first. You may stop at any point.

What this file contains

1 complete case. Each has shared information, separate A/B clue sheets, optional hints, the answer with reasoning, and its story ending.

This PDF and the corresponding HTML edition contain the same case, not extra puzzles. You do not need to buy a second format.

Case 1: shared sheet p.2; A p.3; B p.4; answer and ending p.5.

AI-assisted original fiction. Fictional people and places. For private noncommercial play with the purchaser/recipient present; no redistribution, resale, public uploads or commercial events.

Case 1 · The shelf handover

SHARED INFORMATION - BOTH PLAYERS MAY READ

The archive has closed for the evening. Exhibition staff Nao, 32, and Ren, 35, are preparing tomorrow’s “Harbor Memories” display. An old map will go by the entrance so visitors can trace the town’s walking routes with a finger. Four documents were swapped between storage shelves three times. Nao recorded the first and last operations; Ren recorded the middle one. Join their records to find the map’s current shelf before collecting it.

Arrangement before the three operations

Position	Description
Shelf 1	Folded harbor map
Shelf 2	Group photograph at the pier
Shelf 3	Opening-day visitors’ book
Shelf 4	First screening program

Shelf numbers 1, 2, 3 and 4 are fixed: the shelves themselves do not move. Each shelf holds one of the four documents above. Every operation swaps the contents of two different shelves. Operations 1, 2 and 3 happen once each, in that order, with no other moves. A pair of shelves may be swapped again in another operation. Find the map’s location after operation 3.

Which shelf holds the map after all three operations?

Shelf 1: The map’s location after operation 3

Shelf 2: The map’s location after operation 3

Shelf 3: The map’s location after operation 3

Shelf 4: The map’s location after operation 3

Our answer: _____

Our reason: _____

Case 1 · The shelf handover

PLAYER A ONLY - KEEP SEPARATE FROM THE OTHER CLUE

Card A · The first and last entries

I recorded operations 1 and 3.

Operation 1: swap the documents in shelves 1 and 2.

Operation 3: swap the documents in shelves 3 and 4.

Operation 2 happened between these two. Do not jump straight from operation 1 to operation 3: ask your partner for the missing middle entry.

Discuss your information with your partner. Both players may look at the shared sheet. Keep the answer sheet covered.

OPTIONAL HINT - cover or fold back until wanted

The map starts in shelf 1. Where does operation 1 move it? Tell your partner that position, ask what operation 2 does, then apply operation 3.

Case 1 · The shelf handover

PLAYER B ONLY - KEEP SEPARATE FROM THE OTHER CLUE

Card B · The middle entry

I recorded operation 2.

Operation 2: swap the documents in shelves 2 and 3.

This is the middle of three operations. Ask your partner where the documents are immediately before it, then describe their positions after this swap.

Discuss your information with your partner. Both players may look at the shared sheet. Keep the answer sheet covered.

OPTIONAL HINT - cover or fold back until wanted

Swap the documents in shelves 2 and 3 after operation 1, not the documents that occupied those shelves in the starting arrangement.

Case 1 · The shelf handover

ANSWER AND COMPLETE CASE ENDING - KEEP COVERED UNTIL READY

Answer

Shelf 4

Why this is the answer

The map starts in shelf 1. Operation 1 swaps shelves 1 and 2, moving the map to shelf 2. Operation 2 swaps shelves 2 and 3, moving it to shelf 3. Operation 3 swaps shelves 3 and 4, so it finishes in shelf 4. The final arrangement is photograph, visitors' book, screening program, map in shelves 1 through 4. Card A leaves the middle swap unknown. Card B leaves the swaps before and after it unknown. Neither card alone identifies the map's final shelf.

How this case ends

Ren lifts the map from shelf 4. An old ferry landing's name appears between its folds. Nao spreads it across the low display table by the entrance and adds a small label with today's street names. "Someone visiting for the first time might want to walk this route." They put the photograph and visitors' book in their assigned places and record the shelves' final arrangement on the handover sheet. The map is ready to welcome tomorrow's visitors; the storage task is finished.

Another case at the archive

This free case is complete. The optional paid collection contains this same case plus one different case and the collection's closing story. The English PDF and English/Japanese HTML editions contain the same two cases. No purchase is needed to finish this case.

See the two-case collection: https://tiny-deduction-lab.itch.io/the-night-archive

Check the current price, final total and formats on the product page before paying. For private noncommercial play only.